

Mimicry

An Evolutionary Play

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CAST OF CHARACTERS

MIMI, a golden-crested myna who can mimic and paraphrase sound and is full of stories to tell

Amusing, Demeaning, Noble

CRYSTAL, a green tree monitor who speaks with a forked tongue and stands stories tall

Curious, Obtrusive, Powerful



✿ Androgyny Zoology: Each character resembles the androgynous nature

✿ Queer People of the Global Majority most represent the experiences of these legendary animals; cast accordingly

NOTES

/ - two options or read the one matching a specific character

0. SPARK

FOREST, SOUTHEAST ASIA

A bird tweets and a lizard hisses.

MIMI, a myna bird, enter away from the stage. They search about until they get spooked at the sight of an AUDIENCE MEMBER.

A campfire ignites in the middle of a dark forest. Every sound of nature is audible in the distance.

1. INCIPIENT

MIMI swoops in onto the stage.

CRYSTAL, a monitor, crawls out.

MIMI performs a birdlike dance, symbolizing nobility. They mimic the sounds of nature.

CRYSTAL expresses such power with their monitor presence. They mimic the surrounding environment.

MIMI & CRYSTAL

Light at night. What a sight.
Is this right? Night with light?

Night bequeathed. Sight to teach.
Right beseeched. Light in reach.

Night released. Sight to meet.
Right to seed. Light is heat-

MIMI and CRYSTAL touch the fire,
burning a wing or a leg.

MIMI & CRYSTAL (CONT'D)

Dead! Heated! Healing...

MIMI and CRYSTAL face each other.

MIMI & CRYSTAL (CONT'D)

Heathen! Where are my babies?! Where'd you hide them eggs? You seek mine, too? *Mine*?! My intentions are for you to give me your attention. Do you have an original thought, monitor lizard/myna bird?

CRYSTAL

I've settled here. Does that answer your question?

MIMI

I'm a vagabond. Your answer settles not well with me.

CRYSTAL

Well, a myna bird should never settle.

MIMI

Eggs gotta be laid somewhere.

CRYSTAL

Eggs should be laid where their ancestors laid.

MIMI

It does not make it right for you to hide my eggs!

CRYSTAL

I hid no eggs. I am busy with mine, now missing.

MIMI

I eat nothing but bugs.

CRYSTAL

You're more a snake than my own cousins.

MIMI

And you have mouth for worms.

A firefly flies by CRYSTAL.

CRYSTAL catches the firefly in their mouth.

CRYSTAL

My mouth worm is an efficient hunter.

A firefly flies by Mimi.

MIMI tries to catch the firefly. Instead, they lead the firefly to being fried in the campfire.

The firefly drops to a crisp on the ground.

MIMI

I killed my meal without laying a feather.

CRYSTAL

Is that firefly even edible now?

MIMI eats the fried firefly from the ground.

MIMI

A firefly is a firefly for a reason.

CRYSTAL snatches another firefly and puts them into the campfire. They eat the fried firefly.

MIMI (CONT'D)

Fire? Am I right?

CRYSTAL

What would be more right...

CRYSTAL grabs leaves. They catch another firefly and fry it. Then with the leaves, they create a smore.

CRYSTAL (CONT'D)

Want... S... More?

MIMI

Smore...? Eh, smore.

CRYSTAL

I know you don't have a worm for a tongue, but you can make your own worm.

CRYSTAL hands MIMI a branch.

MIMI

Thank you for this olive branch.

CRYSTAL grabs a branch for herself.

CRYSTAL

You should not be the one to have all the fun.

MIMI and CRYSTAL catch fireflies.

2. GROWTH

The campfire progresses.

MIMI and CRYSTAL sit by the campfire with fireflies on sticks.

MIMI

I have not eaten since I last touched the Sun.

CRYSTAL

You get to touch the Sun?

MIMI

Yes.

CRYSTAL

Flying must be fun.

MIMI

Flying must be fun.

CRYSTAL

Pardon?

MIMI

Pardon?

CRYSTAL

Give this a rest, you mocking bird.

MIMI

Resting on a tree is the life. I can do that, too.

CRYSTAL

Every time you speak, it's always *me, me, me-*

MIMI

That's my name: Mimi.

CRYSTAL

Mimi, you're a smart arse. Do you know how fireflies are able to light up their bellies?

MIMI uses the campfire and their theatrical physique to represent the origin story of the fireflies.

MIMI

They say that the fireflies are the broken spirits of an enlightening creature.

CRYSTAL

They?

MIMI

The tribal myna birds that I've encountered on my journey told me this fable.

CRYSTAL

Mynas making up myths.

MIMI

I wholeheartedly believe in spirits. This is no myth to me.

CRYSTAL

Who is this enlightening creature?

MIMI

The brightest of them all. The creature that built the Sun, but they grew weary in the feat.

CRYSTAL

Of course. It's sturdy so that you don't break it when you fly into it.

MIMI

At least I can touch it.

CRYSTAL

Touché.

MIMI

The Sun came to life. They are alive.

CRYSTAL

Oh... really?

MIMI

This creature could not sleep. They could rest. They regretted making light that could not be turned off.

CRYSTAL

I'd grow restless, too.

MIMI

The creature made a deal to the Sun. If the Sun rested for half the time, the source of light for the world would be this creature's broken spirit known as fireflies.

CRYSTAL

So, why are we eating their spirits?!

MIMI

We're not eating them. We're sending them onto the path to the after-world.

CRYSTAL

Where they would assemble themselves?

MIMI

Maybe. Light does not replace others, but build upon one another.

CRYSTAL

That's the only reasoning that you've made real sense of thus far.

MIMI

You have no sense of curiosity for the meaning of *all this*?

CRYSTAL

I am pretty sure there is a scientific reasoning behind their light-up bodies.

MIMI

And tree monitor, *clearly* it looks like you know the science. What do you call yourself?

CRYSTAL

Crystal.

MIMI

Wow, are you bright or is that your forked tongue of yours speaking?

CRYSTAL

Very funny. I was the last to hatch. I was a gem in an empty nest.

MIMI

You had no one to pass on your history?

CRYSTAL

No story.

MIMI

What kind of life is that?

CRYSTAL

All I know is this forest.

MIMI

Do you get out to the water often?

CRYSTAL

I felt the rain. Isn't that enough?

MIMI

But out there, there are other creatures who made a home out of the rain.

CRYSTAL

There are animals that can breathe underwater?

MIMI

Yes.

CRYSTAL

I don't believe in your fables.

MIMI

It's true. They don't have legs like us, but they have wings like me.

CRYSTAL

Can they fly?

MIMI

No, they are like me but use their wings to move through water.

CRYSTAL

I dreamt of flying.

MIMI

Then, try it.

CRYSTAL

If you've noticed, I do not have wings.

MIMI

Build one.

CRYSTAL

The world is my oyster?

MIMI

Well, at least your ancestors did not evolve into clam shells.

CRYSTAL

Your jokes are mollusks.

MIMI

Wait, you said you don't believe there are creatures who make homes in water.

CRYSTAL

Oysters are not real.

MIMI

You've heard of them.

CRYSTAL

Do you have something to say about the legendary oysters?

MIMI

I am paraphrasing but-

CRYSTAL

You're the king/queen of paraphrasing.

MIMI

You're the king/queen of para-what-a-now.

CRYSTAL

Your gold crest reminds me of a noble.

MIMI

Your green scales remind me of grass. The ground that I do not have to walk on.

CRYSTAL

You certainly have the ego of a tyrant.

MIMI

I'm surprised your forked tongue has not gotten you to rant.

CRYSTAL

Looks like your ancestors devolved to losing your pearls.

MIMI

At least, I had pearls.

MIMI demonstrates their heirloom
of any sort from their gold-
crested myna family.

CRYSTAL

It helps when they're heirlooms. But you make a bad parent.

MIMI

As a first-time parent, you're not doing so well either.

CRYSTAL

Monitors do not typically monitor their own children. I'm the exception.

MIMI

You accepted hiding in trees all your life?

CRYSTAL

Don't birds do that, too?

MIMI

I cannot hide in trees. I stick out.

CRYSTAL

Like a branch.

MIMI

You tree lizards are so fascinating.

CRYSTAL

How so?

MIMI

I would not be so grateful for my parents abandoning me before I hatched.

CRYSTAL

I'm always hatching an evil plan against them.

MIMI

I'm sure it will unfold some day.

CRYSTAL

Have you forgiven your parent?

MIMI

For what?

CRYSTAL

For feeding you puke. Literal vomit.

MIMI

Ew, never.

CRYSTAL

Are you going to break the cycle?

MIMI

Why would I if it has worked for generations?

CRYSTAL

What made you decide to be a parent?

MIMI

Same as you I'm sure.

MIMI (CONT'D)

To pass on my spirit.

CRYSTAL

To pass on my blood.

CRYSTAL (CONT'D)

I know not of my parents' spirit, so blood it is.

MIMI

But no matter what, we are always a reflection of our parents.

CRYSTAL

Is copying your parents an offensive or defensive mechanism?

MIMI

Is copying your parents an offensive or defensive mechanism?

CRYSTAL

Copying me is definitely offensive.

MIMI

Copying me is definitely offensive.

CRYSTAL

Do you have an original thought or do you like mimicking everyone, Mimi?

MIMI

Do you speak in anything other than forked
tongue, Crystal?

CRYSTAL

Go fork-

MIMI

You go fork yourself!

CRYSTAL

This forked tongue wished it had tasted your
eggs!

MIMI

You snake!

CRYSTAL paces around the campfire.

CRYSTAL

My feet walks on eggshells.

MIMI

Your attitude does not help.

CRYSTAL

Birds of a feather flock together.

MIMI

You'll never be a bird.

CRYSTAL

This lizard wants no gizzards for a stomach. I
want something enlightening like a firefly.

MIMI

You certainly have a fire in your belly. Stop
dragging on. So you know where my eggs-

CRYSTAL

Speaking of snakes, they are my reptilian
cousins.

MIMI

There is a reason they have no legs to stand
on.

CRYSTAL

What contrived myth do you have under your
wings this time?

MIMI

Legend has it that they lost their legs because
they wished too hard for wings that they were
not grateful for the legs they had.

CRYSTAL

You're definitely my evolutionary enemy. Prey!

MIMI

Pray that you say nothing more foolish than this!

CRYSTAL

I wouldn't eat you even in your current pathetic state.

MIMI

Forked tongue and flames in your stomach. I expect nothing more from a lizard.

CRYSTAL

You've never really touched the Sun, have you?

MIMI

That Sun matters less with my sons. I cannot find mine and you'll never hold yours if you don't tell me where they are!

CRYSTAL

Egg me on! I pray that your own spirits are broken into countless pieces!

MIMI

At least I have a spirit!

MIMI and CRYSTAL tossle.

MIMI & CRYSTAL

Break my spirit!

3. FULLY DEVELOPED

The campfire drops eggshells as it grows to maximum strength.

MIMI and CRYSTAL walk on eggshells.

MIMI & CRYSTAL (CONT'D)

Baby?! No-

MIMI and CRYSTAL hold eggshells. As bird and lizard, they cry out for their dead children.

The fireflies die out.

MIMI and CRYSTAL wander about.

MIMI & CRYSTAL (CONT'D)

The spirits of my ancestors... They end with me. They broke in hellfire!

The sounds are muffled by the
distant sounds of humans.

CRYSTAL

I first heard these sounds not too long ago. It
was an unfamiliar tone. A language none of my
neighbors in the ecosystem has ever spoken
before. Hard to sit on. Tough to understand.
None of our mother tongue.

MIMI uses the campfire and their
physique to represent humans.

MIMI

They are the monsters' tongue.

CRYSTAL

They sound too foolish to be.

MIMI

As a hatchling, my mother/father once told me
the tale of these two-foot beasts.

CRYSTAL

So, monkeys?

CRYSTAL pretends to be a monkey.

MIMI

Listen. These beasts eat everything in sight.

CRYSTAL

Impossible.

MIMI

Evolution treats them as legends. They are the
king/queen of the food chain.

CRYSTAL

My kind are the lords of this forest.

MIMI

Rest assured, you're a peasant's meal.

CRYSTAL

What sick parent raised you to speak to me that
way?

MIMI

A parent who never came back.

CRYSTAL

Where are they?

MIMI

No longer here.

CRYSTAL

Now spirits?

MIMI

I could still smell their hot feathers, flesh
as I flew high and above a village.

CRYSTAL

Village?

MIMI

The two-feet beasts' nest.

CRYSTAL

You left your home?

MIMI

I did not know how to fly the day before. My
mom/dad could not teach me.

CRYSTAL

I was most fortunate to grow up alone and fight
fire with fire.

MIMI

Why do your eggs matter now?

CRYSTAL

I wanted to be different from my parents. The
ones I've never met.

MIMI

You saw the light.

CRYSTAL

Your chicks certainly saw the light.

MIMI

If only we could make light, of this.

CRYSTAL

The two-feet beasts. Those monsters!

MIMI

Unlike any other animal, they can make light
everlasting.

CRYSTAL

Mimi. Where does fire come from?

MIMI

People.

CRYSTAL

No. Really. Where does fire come from?

MIMI

The spirit.

Mother nature speaks through the flora and fauna that is audibly expressing themselves in the darkness. The forest spirits are calling out.

Countless fireflies suddenly swarm the environment.

MIMI mimics the calls of every animal while CRYSTAL scales every plant.

MIMI and CRYSTAL touches the campfire without burning themselves.

CRYSTAL

We, too, can make light everlasting.

CRYSTAL grabs a branch and makes a single torch from the campfire.

Another campfire appears in the distance. Humans are audible.

MIMI & CRYSTAL

The myths are true. This legend must end.

MIMI gathers several branches and makes wings out of them.

CRYSTAL

I cannot fly.

CRYSTAL gathers branches and makes torches out of them.

MIMI plants CRYSTAL makeshift wings on CRYSTAL's back.

MIMI

This will fly. It's on you to spit fire.

CRYSTAL hands MIMI the torches.

CRYSTAL

It's on you to hide your feathers and show the flames.

MIMI and CRYSTAL are ready to fight fire with fire.

MIMI & CRYSTAL
Let's not make light of this.

4. DECAY

MIMI and CRYSTAL hide in the shadows.

Human shadows and silhouettes enter the space.

With shadow puppetry and flaming objects, MIMI and CRYSTAL go on a rampage against the human invaders and quash them.

MIMI fights with nobility like a phoenix.

CRYSTAL wields power like a dragon.

There are audible human screams that cry out: "Fear!"

MIMI (SHADOW)
(Repeating)
Fear me!

CRYSTAL (SHADOW)
Drag on!

MIMI (SHADOW)
(Repeating)
Drag on?!

There are audible screams that decay: "Phoenix" and "Dragon." The humans will remember MIMI and CRYSTAL for millennia to come. The humans run away.

MIMI & CRYSTAL (SHADOWS)
Nature is dead! Heated! Healing...

5. FLASHOVER

MIMI & CRYSTAL (SHADOWS) (CONT'D)
Light at night. What a sight.
This is right. Knights of light.

Night bequeathed. Sight to teach.
Right beseeched. Light in reach.

Night released. Sight to meet.
Right to seed. Light is heat.

The emblems of a phoenix and dragon are present.

MIMI and CRYSTAL, as the Phoenix and the Dragon, run in and spook the AUDIENCE.

The campfires burn out. Blackout.

The Phoenix caws while the Dragon roars.

END OF PLAY